Chicken Chanko Nabe (5-Day Meal Prep)

Serves 5 (meal-prep containers)

Ingredients

The Meatballs & Chicken

- Ground Chicken – 1 lb (454g), 97% lean
- Egg – 1 large
- Ginger – 1 tbsp, grated
- Green Onions – 3, finely chopped
- Cornstarch – 1 tbsp
- Soy Sauce – 1 tbsp (15ml)
- Neutral Oil – 1 tbsp (keeps the lean meatballs moist)
- Boneless Skinless Chicken Thighs – 3 (about 12 oz / 340g), cut into 1-inch pieces

The Broth

- Water – 10 cups (2.4L)
- Dashi Powder – 1 tbsp (Hondashi recommended)
- Soy Sauce – 1/3 cup (80ml), plus more to taste
- Mirin – 1/4 cup (60ml)
- Sake – 1/4 cup (60ml), or dry sherry
- Garlic Cloves – 3, minced
- White Miso – 2 tbsp

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Ingredients (Continued)

Vegetables, Tofu & Udon

- [ ] Daikon – 8 oz (225g), peeled and cut into 1/4-inch (6mm) half-moons
- [ ] Carrots – 2, peeled and sliced into 1/4-inch (6mm) coins
- [ ] Napa Cabbage – 1.5 lbs (680g), cut into 2-inch pieces, stems and leaves kept apart
- [ ] Shiitake Mushrooms – 8, stems removed, caps left whole (or 5 oz pre-sliced)
- [ ] Leeks – 2, white and light green parts only, sliced 1/2-inch (1cm) thick on the diagonal
- [ ] Firm Tofu – 14 oz (400g), cut into 1-inch cubes
- Dried Udon – 1 pack, 14 oz (about 2 oz / 55g per bowl)
- Shichimi Togarashi or Sesame Oil – to taste (optional)

Notes

- **Storage:** Keeps 3–4 days in the refrigerator, which is why the day 4 and 5 containers go in the freezer. Never store the udon in the broth; it turns mushy.

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Instructions

1. **Prep Everything**
   Grate the ginger, chop the green onions, and mince the garlic. Cut the vegetables, chicken, and tofu as listed, keeping the cabbage stems apart from the leaves. Rinse the sliced leeks in a bowl of water to wash out grit, then drain. Measure out everything marked with a spoon.

2. **Make the Meatball Mix**
   In a bowl, combine the ground chicken, egg, ginger, green onions, cornstarch, soy sauce, and oil. Mix by hand until sticky, then cover and refrigerate until step 5 (chilled mix is easier to scoop).

3. **Build the Broth**
   In a large pot (8 qt is ideal, 6 qt at minimum), combine the water, dashi powder, soy sauce, mirin, sake, and garlic. Bring to a boil over high heat, then lower to medium-low for a gentle simmer.

4. **Cook the Root Vegetables**
   Add the daikon and carrots. Simmer until fork-tender but still firm (10 minutes).

5. **Add the Chicken**
   Add the thighs and simmer (5 minutes). Spoon in the meatball mix, about 2 tbsp each (around 16), and simmer until they reach 165°F (10 minutes).

6. **Finish the Pot**
   Add the cabbage stems, shiitake, leeks, and tofu and simmer (3 minutes). Push the cabbage leaves under the broth and simmer (2 minutes). Take the pot off the heat. In a small bowl, whisk the miso with a ladle of broth until smooth, then stir it into the pot. Taste; add soy sauce 1 tsp at a time if needed.

7. **Cool and Portion**
   Let the pot cool (20 minutes). Divide the solids evenly between 5 containers (1 qt / 1L each) and ladle the broth over. Refrigerate 3; freeze 2 for days 4–5.

8. **Serve**
   If the container is frozen, thaw it in the fridge overnight. Boil 2 oz (55g) of udon in a separate pot of water (8 minutes), drain, and put it in a bowl. Meanwhile, heat the chanko in a small pot until it just simmers (a hard boil dulls the miso), or microwave it until steaming (3–4 minutes, stirring halfway). Pour it over the noodles and top with shichimi togarashi or sesame oil.